



Chapter 1: Introduction

Regional Context, Governance Structure, and Strategic Framework

1. Regional Context

Located along the I-95, I-85, and I-295 corridors about 25 miles south of Richmond, the Tri-Cities region is situated at the confluence of the James and Appomattox Rivers. The Tri-Cities Area Metropolitan Planning Organization (TCAMPO) is the federally designated planning body responsible for transportation planning in south-central Virginia's Tri-Cities region. Contained within the Crater Planning District Commission (PDC), TCAMPO is composed of six member jurisdictions, including the independent cities of Colonial Heights, Hopewell, and Petersburg and portions of the adjoining Chesterfield, Dinwiddie, and Prince George Counties. The Tri-Cities region is part of the Greater Richmond Region, which is defined by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB) as the Richmond, Virginia Metropolitan Statistical Area (MSA).

Figure 1 depicts the TCAMPO planning area in the context of the Richmond MSA. According to the 2020 decennial census, the population of TCAMPO was 167,920. With a land area of approximately 324 square miles, the MPO has a population density of approximately 518 people per square mile. Among all MPOs in Virginia, TCAMPO is ranked fifth in terms of population, sixth in land area, and tenth in population density. Although the population of the Tri-Cities region grew by 24.4 percent between the last two decennial censuses, it lags behind the state (39.5 percent) and the nation (33.3 percent).

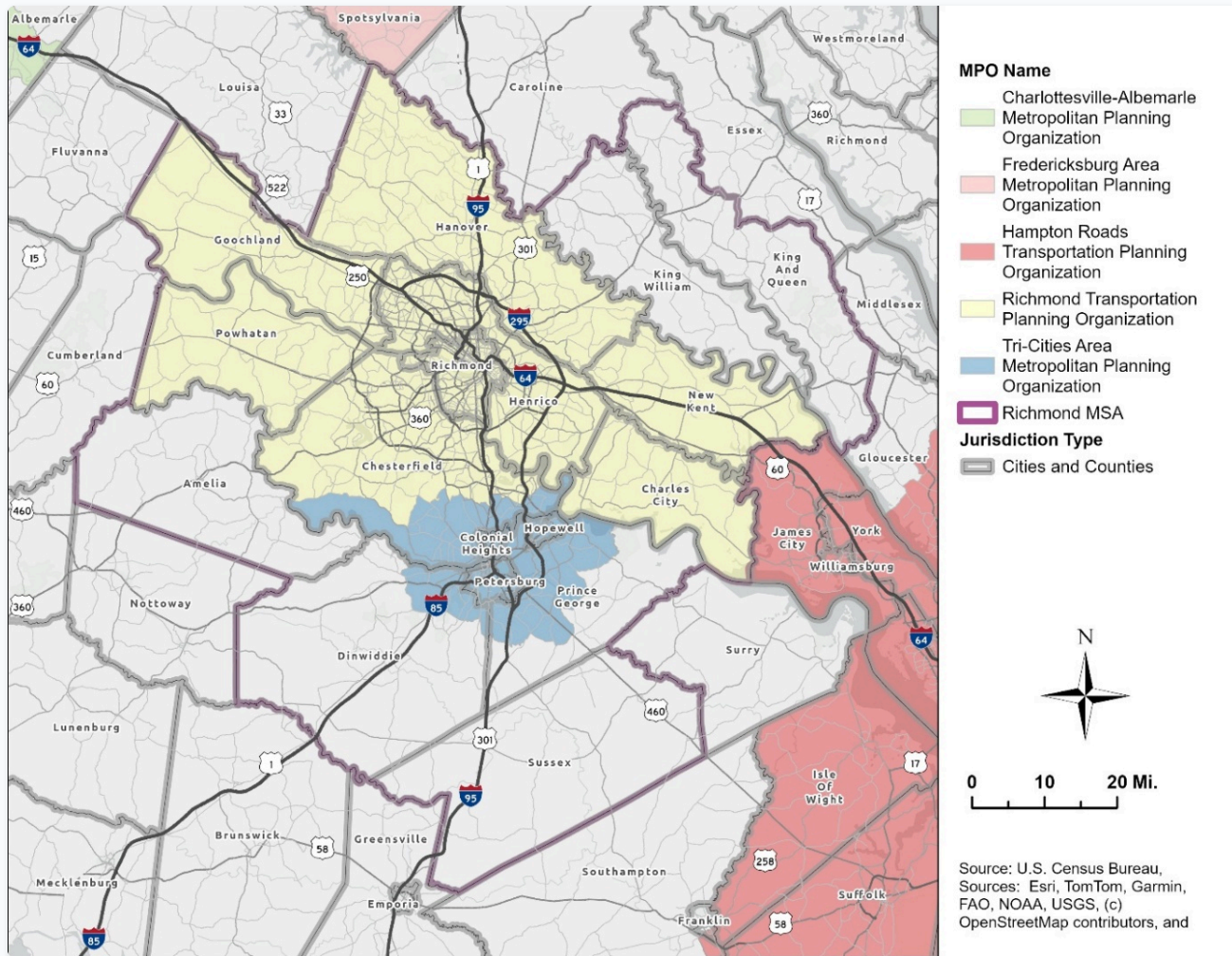


Figure 1. Greater Richmond Region and Metropolitan Planning Organization Boundaries

Unincorporated communities located within the Tri-Cities region include portions of Chester, Enon, Ettrick, Fort Gregg-Adams (Fort Lee), Matoaca, and Prince George. These communities, which are defined as Census Designated Places (CDP) by the United States Census Bureau, are integral to the TCAMPO planning area. Ettrick is home to Virginia State University (VSU), the region's largest university or college. Fort Lee is a large United States Army post and is one of the region's largest employers. The Chester, Enon, Matoaca, and Prince George CDPs are additional clusters that contain large residential and commercial activity centers. Each of these communities have significant amounts of the region's employment and housing and are major sources of trip generation. To carry out transportation planning activities for the region, TCAMPO coordinates with its six member jurisdictions, the Virginia Department of Transportation (VDOT), the Department of Rail and Public Transportation (DRPT), Crater PDC, Petersburg Area Transit (PAT), and other planning partners to guide investment in the region's transportation network.

2. TCAMPO Organization and Structure

TCAMPO consists of a Policy Committee and a Technical Advisory Committee (TAC), each playing a distinct role in the regional planning process. The Policy Committee serves as the primary decision-making body and is responsible for adopting all federally required planning products. Voting members include elected representatives from each of the member jurisdictions, appointed representatives from the Office of the Virginia Secretary of Transportation, the Crater Planning District Commission (CPDC), and Petersburg Area Transit (PAT). Representatives from the Federal Transit Administration (FTA), the Federal Highway Administration (FHWA), and DRPT participate as nonvoting members.

The TAC is composed of staff representatives from the member jurisdictions, Secretary of Transportation, PAT, and Crater PDC. It provides technical support and serves in an advisory capacity to the Policy Committee. Representatives from Fort Lee, RideFinders, and the National Park Service at Petersburg National Battlefield participate as advisory, nonvoting members given their importance to transportation in the Tri-Cities region.

Regional and state transportation and air quality planning agencies have executed Memoranda of Agreement pursuant to 23 CFR 450.310, defining the roles and responsibilities of each participating agency. During the long-range planning process, TCAMPO and Richmond Regional Transportation Planning Organization (RRTPO) develop an accompanying Conformity Report to comply with metropolitan transportation and air quality planning requirements.

3. Purpose of the Plan

Plan2050 is TCAMPO's Long Range Transportation Plan (LRTP). Also known as a Metropolitan Transportation Plan (MTP), Plan2050 is a federally required document that establishes the vision, goals, and multimodal investment priorities for the Tri-Cities region's transportation system. As TCAMPO's core long-range planning document, Plan2050 creates a strategic framework for decision-making across the region, guiding investments that improve mobility, safety, equity, and economic development over the next 20 years.

Plan2050 provides the basis from which shorter-range programming documents, such as the Metropolitan Transportation Improvement Program (MTIP), will be developed. Consistent with federal requirements, projects must be in the MPO's current approved LRTP to be eligible for federal transportation funding. Federal regulations also require that the LRTP address a planning horizon of at least 20 years and is fiscally constrained. This means that Plan2050 includes only projects and programs for which a reasonable funding source can be identified. Plan2050 ensures that investments in its transportation network are coordinated, strategic, and aligned with the goals of the communities it serves.

4. Role of TCAMPO

TCAMPO is responsible for carrying out the federally mandated continuing, comprehensive, and cooperative (3C) planning process on behalf of the region's member jurisdictions. In this role, TCAMPO coordinates

regional transportation planning, prioritizes investments, and ensures that federal transportation funds are directed toward projects that reflect the needs and priorities of the Tri-Cities region. In addition to the LRTP, TCAMPO develops and maintains the following federally required planning products:

- **Unified Planning Work Program (UPWP)** – updated annually
- **Metropolitan Transportation Plan (MTP)** – updated every four years
- **Metropolitan Transportation Improvement Program (MTIP)** – updated every four years
- **Congestion Management Process (CMP)** – maintained on an ongoing basis

TCAMPO also maintains a Public Participation Plan and Title VI Compliance Plan in accordance with federal public involvement and civil rights requirements (23 CFR 450.316; 49 U.S.C. 5332). Together, these planning products establish the region's transportation priorities, which in turn guide TCAMPO's role in selecting and recommending projects for federal funding, including the Surface Transportation Block Grant (STBG), Congestion Mitigation and Air Quality (CMAQ), and Transportation Alternatives Program (TAP). Beyond federal allocations, TCAMPO also evaluates and recommends projects through Virginia's SMART SCALE prioritization process and provides technical assistance to its member jurisdictions in developing competitive applications.

5. Federal Regional Transportation Planning Requirements

Federal law requires that transportation plans in urbanized areas with a population of 50,000 or more be developed through the 3C planning process (23 U.S.C. 134; 49 U.S.C. 5303). MPOs must develop and maintain a Long-Range Transportation Plan and a Transportation Improvement Program, each updated every four years. MPOs serving urbanized areas with a population of 200,000 or more, designated as Transportation Management Areas (TMAs), are also required to maintain a Congestion Management Process (23 CFR 450.322).

Federal planning requirements also emphasize performance-driven, outcome based planning, first introduced under MAP-21 in 2012 and continued under the FAST Act and the Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act (IIJA). This framework requires MPOs and states to establish measurable targets tied to national performance goals covering safety, infrastructure condition, system reliability, and freight movement (23 U.S.C. 150; 23 CFR 490), ensuring federal investments advance national transportation priorities.

6. National Transportation Planning Factors

Since the Intermodal Surface Transportation Efficiency Act of 1991 (ISTEA), Congress has identified key planning areas for MPOs and states to consider when developing multimodal transportation plans. MAP-21 established ten planning factors under 23 CFR 450.306 that remain in effect through the FAST Act and IIJA:

1. Support the economic vitality of the metropolitan area, especially by enabling global competitiveness, productivity, and efficiency
2. Increase the safety of the transportation system for motorized and non-motorized users
3. Increase the security of the transportation system for motorized and non-motorized users
4. Increase the accessibility and mobility of people and freight
5. Protect and enhance the environment, promote energy conservation, improve quality of life, and promote consistency between transportation improvements and planned growth and economic development
6. Enhance the integration and connectivity of the transportation system across and between modes for people and freight
7. Promote efficient system management and operation
8. Emphasize the preservation of the existing transportation system
9. Improve the resiliency and reliability of the transportation system and reduce or mitigate stormwater impacts of surface transportation
10. Enhance travel and tourism

7. Federal Performance Measures

Under MAP-21 and continued through the IIJA, MPOs and states must set targets tied to seven national goal areas:

- **Safety:** To achieve a significant reduction in traffic fatalities and serious injuries on all public roads.
- **Infrastructure Condition:** To maintain the highway infrastructure asset system in a state of good repair.
- **Congestion Reduction:** To achieve a significant reduction in congestion on the National Highway System (NHS).
- **System Reliability:** To improve the efficiency of the surface transportation system.
- **Freight Movement and Economic Vitality:** To improve the national freight network, strengthen the ability of rural communities to access national and international trade markets, and support regional economic development.
- **Environmental Sustainability:** To enhance the performance of the transportation system while protecting and enhancing the natural environment.
- **Reduced Project Delivery Delays:** To reduce project costs, promote jobs and the economy, and expedite the movement of people and goods by accelerating project completion.

8. Plan2050 Goals, Objectives, and Performance Measures

Building on the federal planning factors and national goal areas, TCAMPO established seven regional goals to guide Plan2050:

Goal 1: Safety

Significantly reduce fatal and serious injury crashes for all roadway users across the Tri-Cities region through targeted infrastructure improvements, complete streets design, and behavioral programs.

Goal 2: Infrastructure Condition & System Preservation

Maintain the region's highway pavements, bridges, and public transit assets in a state of good repair, prioritizing preservation over high-cost reconstruction.

Goal 3: Congestion Reduction & Operational Efficiency

Optimize the performance of key regional corridors through intelligent transportation systems (ITS), signal coordination, transit priority, and incident management.

Goal 4: Multimodal Mobility & Accessibility

Expand active transportation and transit networks to provide seamless, affordable, and safe connections to jobs, healthcare, education, and essential services for all residents.

Goal 5: Economic Vitality & Freight Movement

Support regional industry clusters, logistics hubs, and military installations (Fort Gregg-Adams) with resilient, reliable highway and rail freight infrastructure.

Goal 6: Environmental Sustainability & Resiliency

Protect regional water resources, reduce transportation-related emissions, promote clean energy fleet adoption, and fortify infrastructure against severe weather events.

Goal 7: Equity & Quality of Life

Ensure that transportation investments are distributed equitably, avoiding disproportionate burdens on historically underserved populations and enhancing overall quality of life.

9. Planning Process

The development of Plan2050 was guided by a rigorous six-step planning methodology designed to align regional priorities with federal regulations:

1. **Data Collection and Conditions Assessment:** Establishing baseline demographic, land use, and travel pattern conditions.
2. **Community and Stakeholder Engagement:** Conducting broad public surveys, interactive workshops, and stakeholder roundtables across all six member jurisdictions.
3. **Scenario Development and Evaluation:** Modeling future travel demand under multiple land use and infrastructure investment scenarios.
4. **Project Identification and Prioritization:** Scoring projects based on federal performance metrics, cost-effectiveness, and equity impacts.
5. **Fiscal Constraint Analysis:** Reconciling anticipated 25-year revenue streams with planned capital investments.
6. **Interagency and Regional Coordination:** Working in close partnership with VDOT, DRPT, Crater PDC, RRTPO, and local governments.